Languages of South East Asia and China

Francis Bond
based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

1. Language families of the region
2. Mainland Southeast Asia as a linguistic area
3. Geography, history and language policy
4. Comparing the features
5. Summary

What we will cover

- Recognised language families of the region
- Impact of geography on human population movement, linguistic diversity and cultures of MSEA
- Indospheric and Sinospheric influences
- Typological features of MSEA languages
  - Lexical tone
  - Phoneme inventories
  - Zero anaphora
  - Classifier systems
  - Serial verb constructions
- What makes MSEA a linguistic area, and why?

Outline

1 Language families of the region

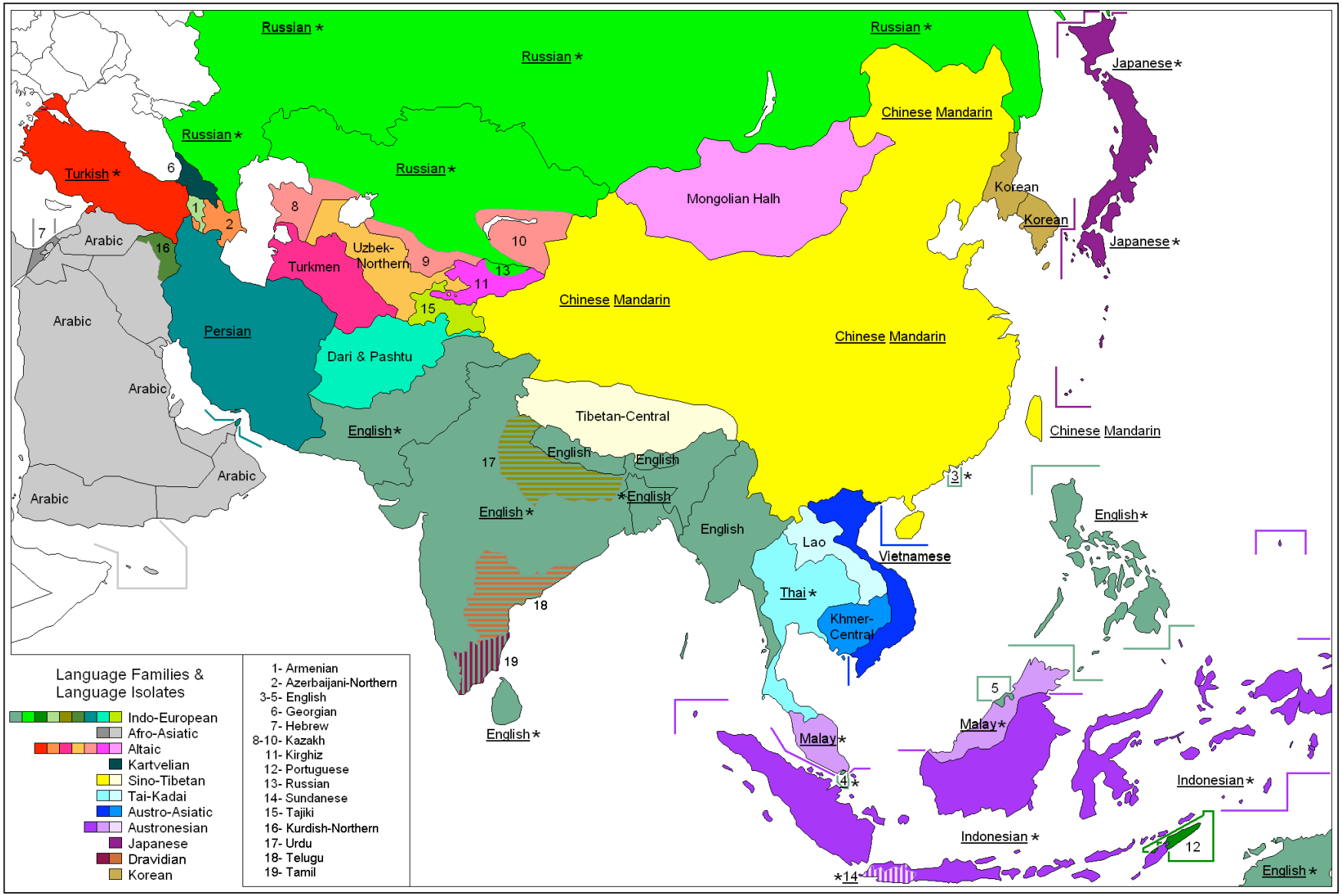
2 Mainland Southeast Asia as a linguistic area

3 Geography, history and language policy

4 Comparing the features

5 Summary

Official Languages



The major language families of SEA

- **Austronesian**: coastal Vietnam, Burma and western peninsular SEA
- **Austroasiatic** (Mon-Khmer; the Munda branch is only in South Asia): scattered throughout MSEA, reaching NE India (Khasian branch)
- **Sino-Tibetan**
  - **Tibeto-Burman**: Burma, NE India, the mountains of western and northern Thailand, Laos and northern Vietnam
  - **Sinitic**: mostly China
- **Tai-Kadai**: southern China, SEA, NE India
- **Hmong-Mien** (Miao-Yao): mostly southern China, extending into SEA
- **Korean, Japanese and Ainu**: Korean Peninsula and Japan

Genetically unrelated, yet sharing many features: MSEA is a linguistic area

The countries/regions of MSEA

- Burma
- Cambodia
- Laos
- Malaysia
- Thailand
- Vietnam
- NE India (arguably eastward of the south bank of the Brahmaputra River)



Much of Mainland Southeast Asia is very mountainous. The people of the uplands have long resisted being governed by central states of the lowland basins — what Scott (2009) calls **Zomia**.

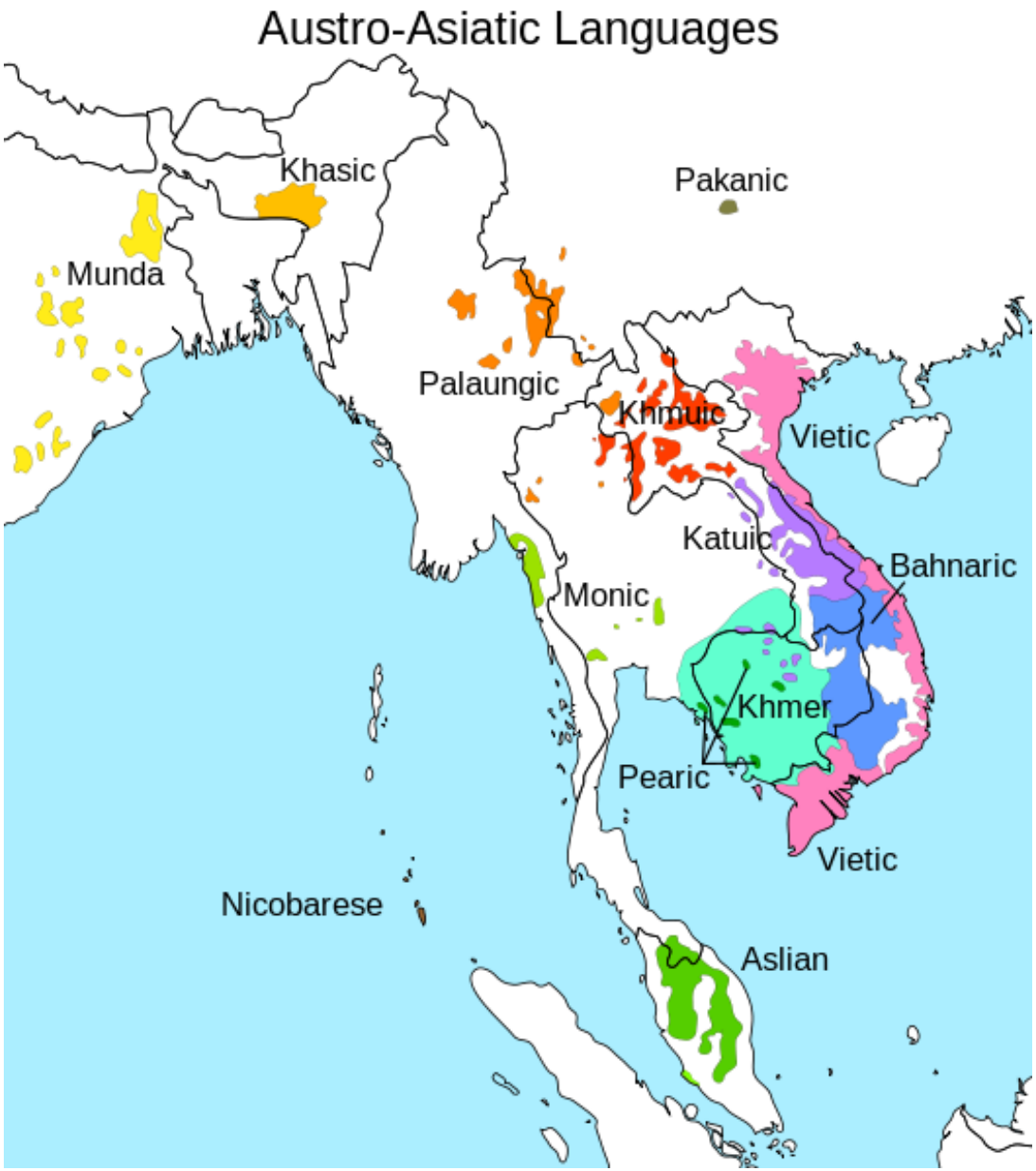
Human and linguistic diversity in MSEA

- Mainland Southeast Asia (MSEA) has high human diversity compared to the global average
  - In social structure, material culture and genetic markers
- Linguistic diversity, however, is regarded as relatively low, although there are around 2,000 languages. Why?

- **Language families**: most languages belong to a few families (Austroasiatic, Tai-Kadai, Sino-Tibetan, Hmong-Mien)
- **Contact and convergence**: trade, migration and exchange have made unrelated languages alike
- **Multilingualism and shift**: lingua francas (Thai, Vietnamese) overshadow the smaller languages
- **Classification**: where linguists draw the line between language and dialect changes the count

Austroasiatic

- Two major branches
  - **Munda**: only in India
  - **Mon-Khmer**: about 145 languages (Ethnologue lists 168 Austroasiatic, 22 of them Munda), from Meghalaya in NE India to Vietnam in the east and the Malay peninsula in the south
- Austroasiatic (AA) languages are also spoken in China


Austro-Asiatic Languages
Khasic
Pakanic
Munda
Palaungic
Khmuic
Vietic
Katuic
Bahnaric
Monic
Khmer
Pearic
Vietic
Nicobarese
Aslian

Mon-Khmer branch of Austroasiatic

- Aslian (mostly endangered): southern Thailand and western Malaysia
- Katuic-Bahnaric: Vietnam, Laos, NE Thailand and Cambodia
- Northern Mon-Khmer (Palaungic and Khmuic): Yunnan and adjacent Burma, northern Thailand and NE Laos
- Vietic (including Vietnamese): Vietnam
- Monic (shrinking): Burma and central Thailand
- Pearic: small groups in western Cambodia and adjacent SE Thailand
- Pakanic (recently proposed): northern Vietnam, Guangxi and Yunnan

Many competing classifications, none universally accepted

Major Mon-Khmer languages

- Khmer (Cambodian, about 13 million speakers)
- Vietnamese (nearly 70 million)



Tibeto-Burman

- About 300 languages, mostly in South Asia; many straddle the border zone with Southeast Asia
- Quite different from Sinitic: agglutinative morphology, verb-final, postpositions
- Major languages
  - Burmese (30 million speakers)
  - Tibetan (5 million)
  - Karen (4 million combined: S'gaw is the largest, at about 2 million)
  - Lolo (Yi) (3 million, spoken in China)
  - Bai (1 million, spoken in China)


MONGOLIA
Northern Mandarin
Northwestern Mandarin
CHINA
Northern Mandarin
Ladakhi
TIBET
Amdo
River Mandarin
Central Tibetan
Wu
Khams
Southwestern Mandarin
Dzonghkha
Wu
NEPAL
BHUTAN
Bai
Gan
Southwestern Mandarin
Xiang
Min
INDIA
BANGLA DESH
Kejia
Min
Burmese
Cantonese
TAIWAN
MYANMAR
LAOS
Min
Hainan Island
Bay of Bengal
THAILAND
South China Sea
Andaman Sea
VIETNAM
Gulf of Thailand
Chinese
Tibetan
Rungic
Tani
Konyak
Naga
Mikir-Meithei
Kuki-Chin
Bodo-Garo
Lolo-Burmese
Kachinic
Karenic
Bai
Qiangic
© 2013 A. Gutman & B. Avanzati

Sinitic Languages

Over 1,000 million speakers, in mainland China, Taiwan and Southeast Asia

- Mandarin
  - Northern
  - Jiang-Huai/Southeastern (Jiangsu and Anhui)
  - Southwest (Hubei, Sichuan, Yunnan, Guizhou, western Hunan, western Guangxi)
- Wu (Southern Jiangsu, Zhejiang)
- Xiang (Hunan)
- Yue (Guangdong, Guangxi, parts of Hainan): Cantonese
- Min (Fujian, Taiwan, parts of Hainan): Hokkien
- Gan (Jiangxi, eastern Hunan, SE Hubei)
- Hakka (southern Jiangxi, north-eastern Guangdong, western Fujian, part of Sichuan, Guangxi, and Taiwan)

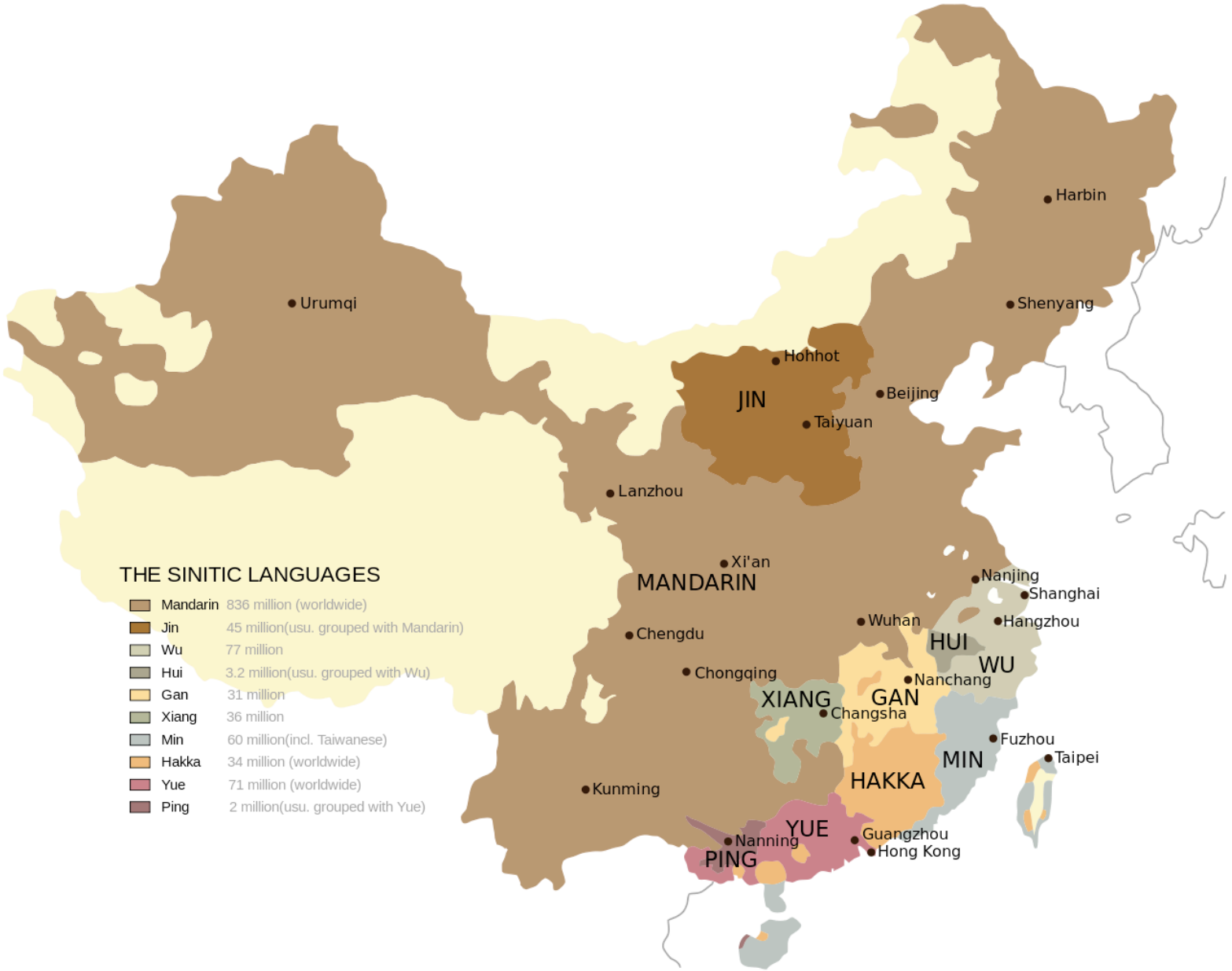
Chinese Dialect Groups and Speakers

Dialect Group	Number of Speakers (millions)
Mandarin	990
Wu (e.g., Shanghainese)	83
Xiang (Hunanese)	38
Yue (Cantonese)	85
Min (e.g., Hokkien, Teochew)	75
Gan	23
Hakka	44

Native speakers, 2012–2023 (Ethnologue, Language Atlas of China, via Wikipedia, accessed 2026-10-28); the numbers depend on migration and classification

According to Goddard (2005, p. 38)

- In the Chinese tradition any variety other than Mandarin is a *dialect*
- This reflects the cultural and historical unity of China and the use of a common script
  although not all words can be written in Hanzi [FCB]
- In normal usage, dialects are mutually intelligible
- Linguists usually refer to the seven language groupings as *Sinitic languages*
- But some of these languages also have many mutually unintelligible varieties
- E.g., Min has as many as nine mutually unintelligible varieties in the Fujian province alone (Li 1992, cited in Goddard 2005, p. 38)
- There are probably hundreds of mutually unintelligible Sinitic languages in China


THE SINITIC LANGUAGES
Mandarin 836 million (worldwide)
Jin 45 million(usu. grouped with Mandarin)
Wu 77 million
Hui 3.2 million(usu. grouped with Wu)
Gan 31 million
Xiang 36 million
Min 60 million(incl. Taiwanese)
Hakka 34 million (worldwide)
Yue 71 million (worldwide)
Ping 2 million(usu. grouped with Yue)
Urumqi
Harbin
Shenyang
Hohhot
Beijing
Taiyuan
JIN
Lanzhou
Xi'an
MANDARIN
Nanjing
Shanghai
Wuhan
Hangzhou
Chengdu
HUI
WU
Chongqing
Nanchang
XIANG
GAN
Changsha
Fuzhou
Taipei
MIN
HAKKA
Kunming
YUE
Guangzhou
Nanning
Hong Kong
PING

Mandarin Romanization Comparison

Characters	Wade-Giles	Hanyu Pinyin	Bopomofo	Notes
中国/中國	Chung^{1}-kuo^{2}	Zhōngguó	ㄓㄨㄥㄍㄨㄛˊ	China
北京	Pei^{3}-ching^{1}	Běijīng	ㄅㄟˇㄐㄧㄥ	PRC Capital
台北	T'ai^{2}-pei^{3}	Táiběi	ㄊㄞˊㄅㄟˇ	RoC Capital
毛泽东/毛澤東	Mao^{2} Tse^{2}-tung^{1}	Máo Zédōng	ㄇㄠˊㄗㄜˊㄉㄨㄥ	Mao Tse-tung
蒋介石/蔣介石	Chiang^{3} Chieh^{4}-shih^{2}	Jiǎng Jièshí	ㄐㄧㄤˇㄐㄧㄝˋㄕˊ	Chiang Kai-shek
孔子	K'ung^{3} Tzu^{3}	Kǒng Zǐ	ㄎㄨㄥˇㄗˇ	Confucius

- **Wade–Giles**: older, once standard in English-language scholarship, still used for names in Taiwan
- **Hanyu Pinyin**: official in China and the international standard; tones marked by diacritics or digits
- **Bopomofo (Zhuyin)**: its own symbols (ㄅㄆㄇㄈ ...), used in Taiwan to teach pronunciation

Sinospheric features

Sino-Tibetan languages in SEA tend to share features with Sinitic, e.g.

- complex tone
- classifiers
- limited morphology
- isolating word formation
- pragmatically determined syntax
- reliance on zero anaphora

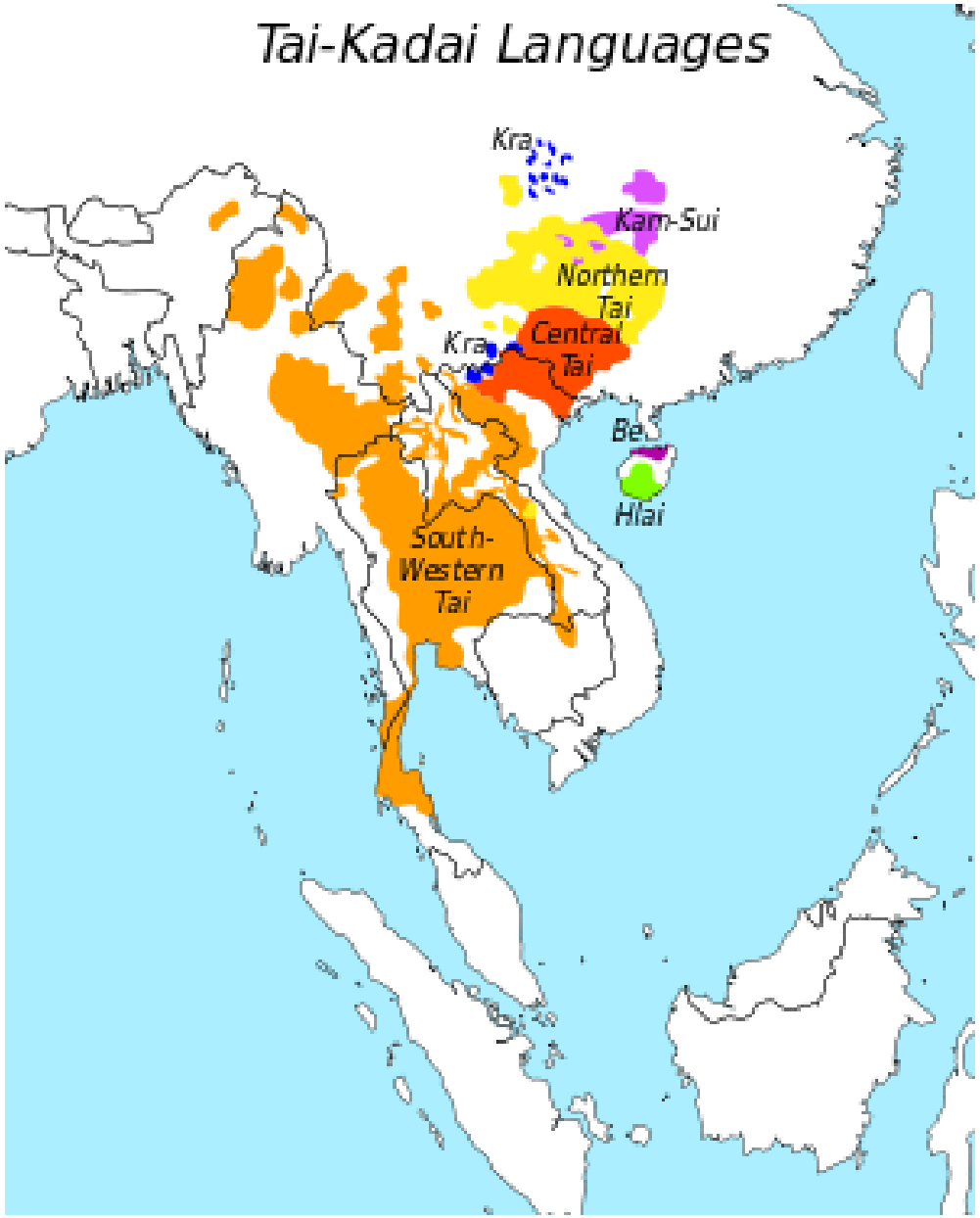
Indospheric features

Sino-Tibetan languages in South Asia tend to share features with Indic, e.g.

- simple tone systems or no lexical tone
- morphologically complex stems
- fusional or agglutinative word formation
- breathy and retroflex consonants
- pronominal cross-referencing on the verb
- well-developed case-marking paradigms

Tai-Kadai

- Three branches: Northern, Central and South-western
- Thai is South-western, a branch reaching as far west as Assam in NE India
- *Tai* (unaspirated dental stop *t*): the family
- *Thai* (aspirated dental stop *th*): the national language of Thailand


Tai-Kadai Languages
Kra
Kam-Sui
Northern Tai
Central Tai
Kra
Be
Hlai
South-Western Tai

Origin of Tai-Kadai

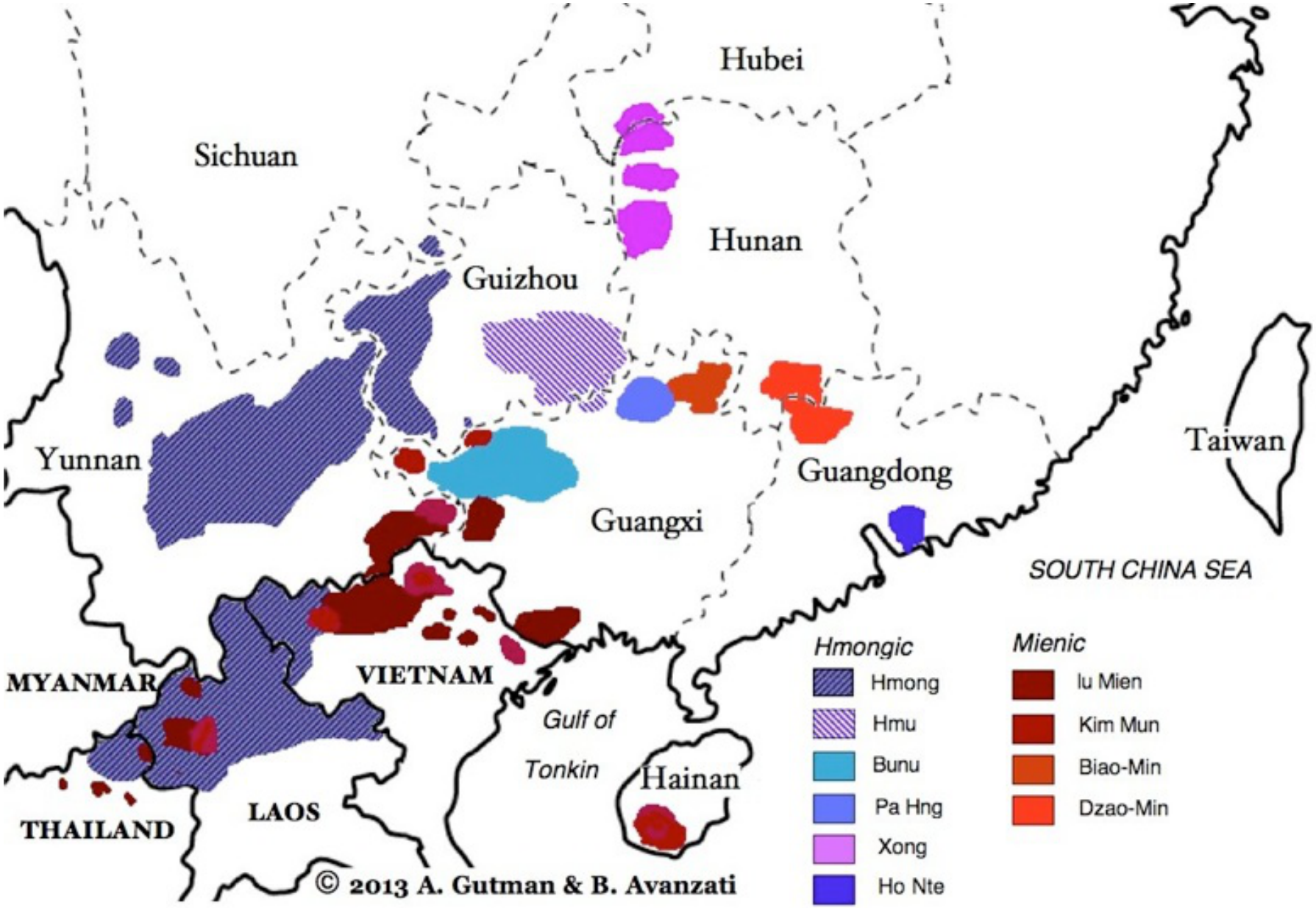
- One parent language, spoken by a single group some 1,500 to 2,000 years ago
- Homeland probably near the present Vietnam/China border
- From there Tai speakers spread to
  - northern Vietnam
  - Laos
  - Thailand
  - southern provinces of China
  - northern Burma
  - Assam in north-eastern India

Major Tai-Kadai Languages

- Thai (60 million speakers)
  could be several languages
- Lao (4 million)
- Over 50 other Tai-Kadai languages

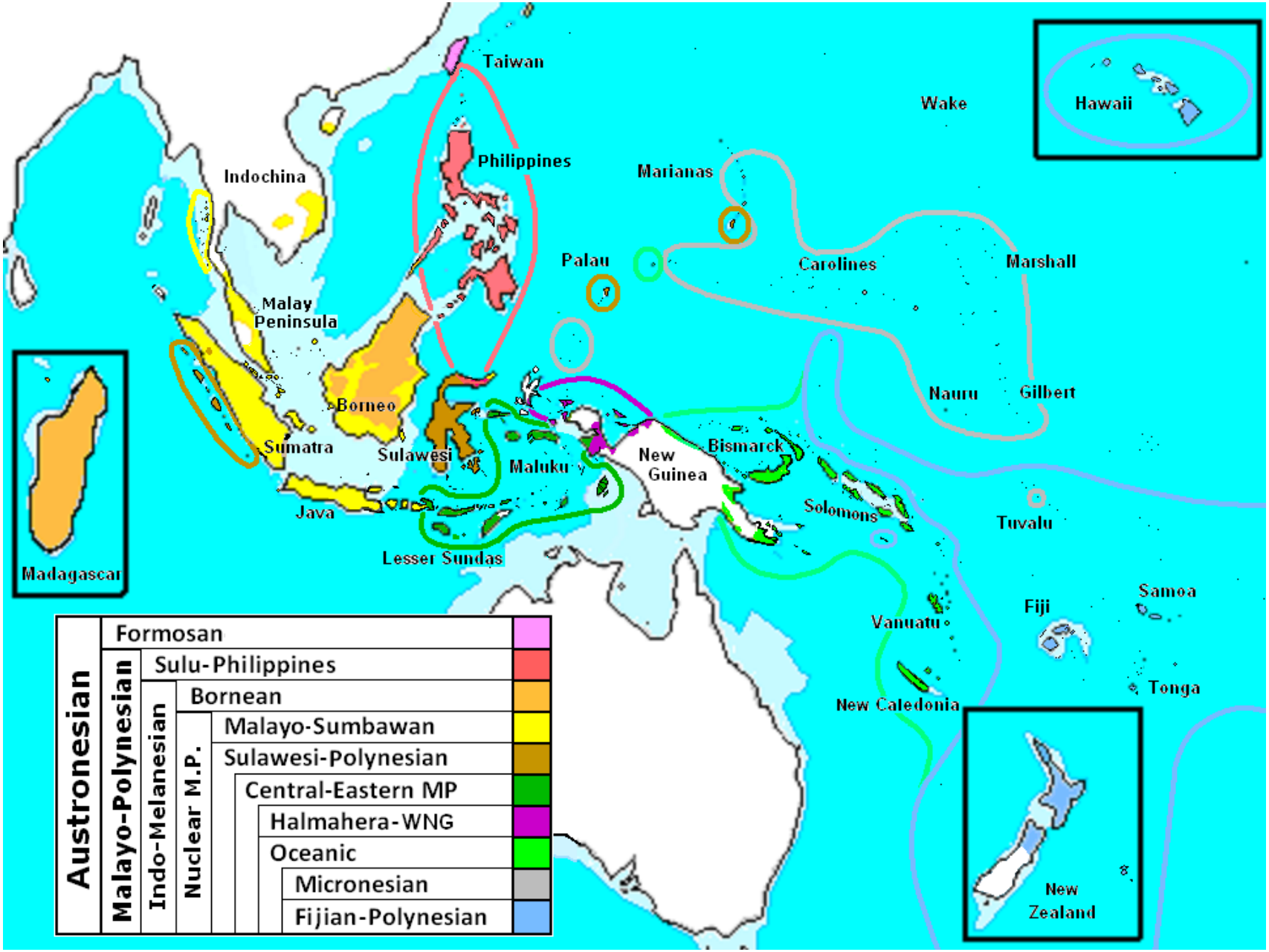
Hmong-Mien

- 35 languages, mainly in southwestern China, several in adjacent parts of Southeast Asia
- Hmong (also known as Miao: 5 million speakers)
- Mien (also known as Man and as Yao: 2 million)
- Mainly spoken in the hills
- Studied mostly by Chinese scholars; little known in the West


Hubei
Sichuan
Hunan
Guizhou
Yunnan
Guangdong
Taiwan
Guangxi
SOUTH CHINA SEA
MYANMAR
VIETNAM
Gulf of
Tonkin
Hainan
LAOS
THAILAND
© 2013 A. Gutman & B. Avanzati
Hmongic
Hmong
Hmu
Bunu
Pa Hng
Xong
Ho Nte
Mienic
Iu Mien
Kim Mun
Biao-Min
Dzao-Min

Austronesian

- The most widespread family in the world: around 1,200 languages, 300 million native speakers
- Beyond Southeast Asia, across the Pacific as far as Easter Island
- A western outpost: Malagasy, on Madagascar
- Major languages
  - Malay (200 million speakers, about 40 million as a first language) Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia) and Malaysian (Bahasa Melayu)
  - Javanese (75 million)
  - Sundanese (30 million)
  - Filipino (Tagalog) (50 million, 30 million as a first language)


Taiwan
Philippines
Indochina
Malay Peninsula
Borneo
Sumatra
Sulawesi
Java
Lesser Sundas
Maluku
New Guinea
Bismarck
Solomons
Vanuatu
New Caledonia
Tuvalu
Fiji
Samoa
Tonga
Wake
Hawaii
Marianas
Palau
Carolines
Marshall
Nauru
Gilbert
Madagascar
New Zealand
Austronesian
Formosan
Malayo-Polynesian
Sulu-Philippines
Indo-Melanesian
Bornean
Nuclear M.P.
Malayo-Sumbawan
Sulawesi-Polynesian
Central-Eastern MP
Halmahera-WNG
Oceanic
Micronesian
Fijian-Polynesian

Japanese, Korean, and Ainu Families

- Japonic: Japanese (125 million speakers)
- Koreanic: Korean (70 million)
- Ainu (isolate, effectively dormant; a handful of elderly speakers, with active revitalisation)
- Japanese and Korean: very similar syntax (agglutinative, case marking, verb final, pre-modification)
- Both borrowed much vocabulary from Chinese

Language	**Script**	**Transliteration**
Mandarin	学校 (學校)	*xuéxiào*
Japanese	学校	*gakkō*
Korean	학교 (學校)	*hakgyo*

Outline

1 Language families of the region

2 Mainland Southeast Asia as a linguistic area

3 Geography, history and language policy

4 Comparing the features

5 Summary

MSEA as a Linguistic Area

- Languages of different families converge when in close contact
- A **linguistic area** (*Sprachbund*): unrelated languages sharing features
- MSEA is one, after centuries of mutual influence
- Shared features in phonology, lexicon and grammar (e.g. limited syllable structures, lexical tone)
- Many features shared with non-mainland languages too

Shared Phonological Features

- A limited range of syllable structures
- Lexical tone across the region: Vietnamese, Thai, most Chinese dialects
- Mon-Khmer languages mostly lack tone (with exceptions)
- Convergence from prolonged contact

Phonological Features: Examples

Mandarin	*mā*	"mother"	high level
(4 tones)	*má*	"hemp"	rising
	mǎ	"horse"	dipping
	mà	"scold"	falling
Thai	*khaa*	"be stuck"	mid
(5 tones)	*khàa*	"galangal"	low
	khâa	"servant, I"	falling
	kháa	"trade"	high
	khǎa	"leg"	rising
Vietnamese	*ma*	"ghost"	level
(6 tones)	*má*	"cheek"	high rising
	mà	"but"	low falling
	mả	"tomb"	falling-rising
	mã	"horse"	glottalized rising
	mạ	"young rice plant"	glottalized falling

- Mandarin syllables are mostly CV or CVN: *mā* "mother", *màn* "slow"
- Consonant clusters are rare

Shared Morphological Features

- Little or no inflectional morphology
- Classifier constructions: counting nouns in Thai and Mandarin
- Similar morphology makes a neighbour's language easier to learn
- Mutual adaptation over time

Classifiers are obligatory when counting

Mandarin	一只猫	*yī zhī māo*	“one cat”
	三本书	*sān běn shū*	“three books”
	五辆车	*wǔ liàng chē*	“five cars”
Thai	เด็กหนึ่งคน	*dèk nùŋ khon*	“one child”
	บ้านสองหลัง	*bâan sɔ̌ɔŋ lăŋ*	“two houses”
	เสื้อผ้าสามตัว	*sûa phâa săam tua*	“three shirts”

Areal Lexicon

- **Areal lexicon**: a term from James Matisoff
- Beyond shared words, shared concepts
- A shared worldview: consensus on what is worth talking about
- Similar cultural vocabulary across unrelated languages

Areal Lexicon: Rice

	rice plant	uncooked grains	cooked rice
Thai	ข้าว *khâaw* “rice in general”; ข้าวเหนียว *khâaw nĭaw* “sticky rice”		
Vietnamese	*lúa*	*gạo*	*cơm*
Japanese	稲 *ine*	米 *kome*	御飯 *gohan*
Indonesian	*padi* (in the field)	*beras* (husked) *gabah* (unhusked)	*nasi*

- Different words for rice at different stages

Areal Lexicon: Kinship

	older	younger
Mandarin	哥哥 *gēge* “older brother”	弟弟 *dìdi* “younger brother”
Thai	พี่ *phîi* “older sibling”	น้อง *nɔ́ɔŋ* “younger sibling”

- Kinship terms mark relative age

Shared Syntactic Features

- Serial verb constructions
- Topic prominence: word order follows the topic
- Ellipsis: context supplies what is left out
- Sentence-final particles express the speaker's attitude

Topic Prominence: Word Order Examples

- **Mandarin Chinese**:

(1) Topic-comment structure:
这 本 书 ，我 看 过 了 。
zhè běn shū , wǒ kàn guò le .
this CLF book 1SG read EXP CRS
“This book, I have read.” [cmn]

- **Japanese**:

(2) Topic marker は *wa*:
象 は 鼻 が 長い 。
zō wa hana ga nagai .
elephant TOP nose NOM long
“Elephants have long noses.” [jpn]

Topic Prominence and Ellipsis

- Sentence structure follows the discourse
- Less rigid word and phrase order
- Ellipsis: understood participants are left out (e.g. the subject, when clear from context)
- Context does much of the work

Ellipsis: Omitting Understood Participants

(3) **Japanese**: ϕ 行き ます 。
ϕ iki masu .
"(I) am going." [jpn]

(4) **Mandarin Chinese**: ϕ 吃 了 吗?
ϕ chī le ma?
"Have (you) eaten?" [cmn]

(5) **Thai**: ϕ ไป ไหน?
ϕ pay nǎy?
ϕ go where?
"(You) go where?" [tha]

Sentence-Final Particles

- Small expressive words at the end of a sentence
- Mark the speaker's feelings or attitude, or a question
- Thai นะ *ná* softens a statement
- Common across mainland Southeast Asia

Sentence-Final Particles: Examples

- **Thai**:
  - คุณสบายดีไหมคะ?
    (*khun sabaay dii mǎy khá*?)
    "How are you?" (*khá* adds politeness from a female speaker)
  - ไปนะ
    (*pay ná*)
    'I'm leaving now, okay?' (*ná* softens the statement)
- **Mandarin Chinese**:

(6) 我们 走 吧。 we go SUGG .
wǒmen zǒu ba .
'Let's go.' (*ba* indicates a suggestion)

(7) 好 吃 吗 ？ good eat Q ?
hǎo chī ma ?
'Is it delicious?' (*ma* turns a statement into a question)

Summary of Areal Features

- Shared features: lexical tone, classifiers, ...
- But variation within families
  - Mon-Khmer: some languages lack tone
  - Tibeto-Burman: mostly verb-final, with postpositions
  - Sinitic: both prepositions and postpositions

Outline

1 Language families of the region

2 Mainland Southeast Asia as a linguistic area

3 Geography, history and language policy

4 Comparing the features

5 Summary

Rivers and mountains shape language distribution

- Major rivers: Irrawaddy, Chao Phraya, Mekong, Red River
- Fertile deltas: large populations, languages spread
- Mountain ranges: linguistic boundaries
- Southern China belongs to the same linguistic area

Uplands and Lowlands

- Lowlands: wet rice supports large populations (Thai, Vietnamese)
- Uplands: shifting agriculture supports smaller groups (Hmong villages at 1,000–1,500 m)
- Elevation sets how people farm and settle

Historical Language Dispersal

- Mon-Khmer speakers inland by 4,000 years ago
- Tai speakers came down from southern China 2,000 years ago, following the river valleys into the lowlands
- Han Chinese expanded southward, driving language shift
- Austronesian in southern Vietnam (the Cham empire)

Rise and Fall of Empires

- 1,000 years ago: Mon-Khmer empires dominated (e.g. the Khmer empire of Angkor)
- Tai kingdoms grew in Laos and Thailand, under Khmer cultural influence
- Mon-Khmer groups shifted to Tai languages
- Tibeto-Burman peoples moved into Myanmar, ending Mon dominance
- Mon now survives in small pockets of eastern Burma

Warfare and Migration

- Wars between Thai, Burmese and Vietnamese reshaped demographics
- Large armies with elephant corps: the kingdom of Lan Xang ("million elephants")
- Migration shifted the ethnic and linguistic mix
- Cultural exchange through conquest and alliance

Hmong-Mien Peoples

- In southwestern China until about 150 years ago, under Han domination
- Moved south under pressure and conflict
- High mountain villages (1,000–1,500 m)
- Minority status preserved culture and language

Colonial Rule in the 19th Century

- British: Myanmar and Malaya
- French: Indochina (Vietnam, Laos, Cambodia)
- Thailand stayed independent, but lost some territory
- Colonial borders became the modern nation-states

Official languages and multilingualism I

Singapore Four official languages: English, Malay, Mandarin and Tamil. Malay is the **national** language and the anthem is sung in it, but English is the language of administration and the medium of education; every child also studies an assigned "mother tongue".

Indonesia *Bahasa Indonesia* is the sole national language, standardised from Riau Malay and adopted by the Youth Pledge of 1928. It is the first language of only a minority, and that is rather the point — it belonged to no dominant group. Javanese has far more native speakers (about 80 million) and no official status. Some 700 local languages.

Philippines Filipino (based on Tagalog) and English are official; the roughly 180 other languages are "auxiliary official languages in the regions". Mother-tongue-based multilingual education was brought into the early grades in 2012 and remains contested.

Official languages and multilingualism II

China The 2000 Law on the Standard Spoken and Written Chinese Language makes Putonghua and simplified characters the standard for government, education and broadcasting. Minority languages have constitutional protection; Sinitic "dialects" such as Cantonese and Hokkien have none.

Timor-Leste Tetum and Portuguese are official, Indonesian and English are "working languages". Around 30 local languages, mostly Austronesian with a handful of Papuan ones.

Official status, national identity, and what people actually speak at home are three different things.

Conclusion: Linguistic Convergence

- Mainland Southeast Asia is a linguistic area
- Shared features come from long contact and mutual influence
- Geography and history decided where the languages are

Outline

1 Language families of the region

2 Mainland Southeast Asia as a linguistic area

3 Geography, history and language policy

4 Comparing the features

5 Summary

Morpho-Syntactic Features I

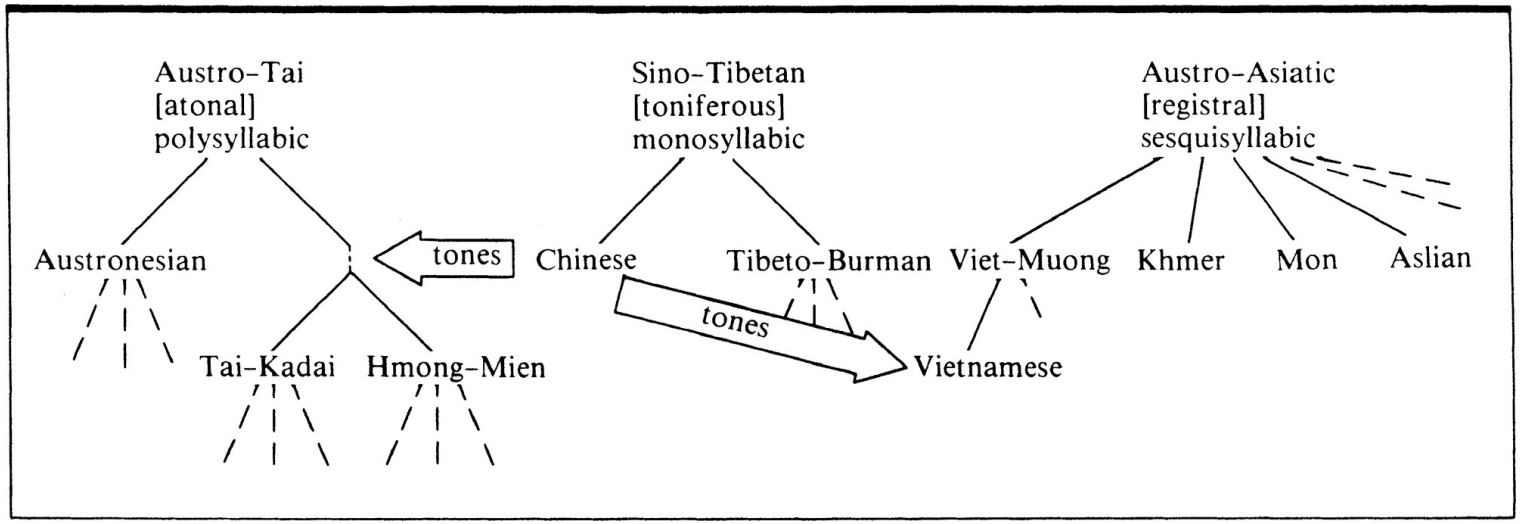
Tone:	lexical tone (+/ – mixed)
Order:	predominant word order (SVO, SOV, ...)
Cl:	classifiers
SFP:	sentence-final particles
SV:	serial verbs
Zero:	zero anaphora or ellipsis (+/ – partial)
Inflect:	inflectional morphology

Morpho-Syntactic Features II

Language	Tone	Order	Cl	SFP	SV	Zero	Inflect
Austronesian	—	VSO/SVO	+	+/-	+	—	—
Austroasiatic	+/-	SVO	+	—	+	+/-	—
Tibeto-Burman	+	SOV	+/-	—	+	+/-	—
Sinitic	+	SVO	+	+	+	+/-	—
Tai-Kadai	+	SVO	+	+	+	+/-	—
Hmong-Mien	+	SVO	+	+	+	+/-	—
Korean/Japanese	—	{SO}V	+	+	+	+	+

The spread of tone in MSEA languages

- Vietnamese developed its 6 tones under Chinese influence, as Haudricourt (1954) showed
- Some Tibeto-Burman languages are developing tone now (the Bodic branch)
- Others are losing it (the Bodo languages of Assam)



Features (and vocabulary) can move across language families!

Outline

1 Language families of the region

2 Mainland Southeast Asia as a linguistic area

3 Geography, history and language policy

4 Comparing the features

5 Summary

Summary I

- Five major language families in Mainland SEA
- Many languages, but relatively low linguistic diversity
- Probably due to centuries of language contact and population movement

Summary II

MSEA languages are characterized by:

- isolating word formation
- tone
- absence of inflectional morphology
- classifier systems
- aspectual and mood systems rather than tense systems
- sentence final particles
- extensive zero anaphora
- serial verb constructions
- re-duplication

Although there are many exceptions

References I

Cliff Goddard. 2005. *The Languages of East and Southeast Asia: An Introduction.* Oxford University Press, Oxford, UK.

André-Georges Haudricourt. 1954. De l'origine des tons en vietnamien. *Journal Asiatique*, 242:69–82. English translation by Martine Mazaudon, Boyd Michailovsky and Alexis Michaud (2018), `https://shs.hal.science/halshs-01678018`.

Charles N. Li. 1992. Chinese. In William Bright, editor, *International Encyclopedia of Linguistics*, volume 1, pages 257–262. Oxford University Press, Oxford and New York. Cited in Goddard (2005: 38).

James C. Scott. 2009. *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia.* Yale University Press, New Haven.